

# Bengali, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one word at a time

Adhithya Rajasekaran

This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they  
are written.

Copyright © Adhithya Rajasekaran. Licensed under Creative Commons  
Attribution-ShareAlike 4.0 International (CC BY-SA 4.0). Bengali set in  
Noto Sans Bengali (SIL Open Font License).



# Preface

This book teaches Bengali one word at a time, and it teaches each word by taking it apart. It is written for someone starting from zero — who may not read a single Bengali letter — so the script is taught *inside the word lessons themselves*: each word introduces exactly the letters it needs, so you learn to read নমস্কার *and* learn what it means in the same few minutes. (A reader who already reads Bengali simply skims the “letters in this word” notes.)

Bengali (*Bāṅglā*) is an **Indo-Aryan** language — descended, like Hindi, Marathi, and Punjabi, from Sanskrit — and the mother tongue of Bengal: West Bengal in India and all of Bangladesh, some 250 million speakers, the seventh-largest language on earth. It is the language of Tagore, and the only one to have furnished the national anthem of *two* nations. One habit runs through the whole book and is worth stating up front: Bengali’s inherent vowel is **ô** (not “a”), its *s* tilts to **sh**, and its *v* collapses to **b** — so Sanskrit *namaskāra* is spoken *nômoshkar*. Learn to hear that shift and every Sanskrit-derived word becomes legible. Roots are traced to Sanskrit and, where they reach, to the wider family that also gave English its words — every form supplied in full.

## How to use this book

Every numbered section is one word, or one small phrase, and takes a few minutes — the length of a queue, an errand, or the walk to the bus. Read them in order the first time through: each section stands on the ones before it, and nothing is used before it has been taught. After that the book becomes reference, and you can open it anywhere.

Say the Bengali out loud wherever you can. The prompts under *Your turn* are written to be spoken, and saying a word is most of what makes it stay. The questions under *Before you move on* carry their own answers in brackets: cover them, answer from memory, then look.

Nothing here is gated behind the alphabet. Each lesson introduces exactly the letters and sounds its own word needs, so you are reading real words from the first page rather than drilling a chart. The whole script is gathered in a reference at the back of the book — somewhere to look things up when you are curious, never a chapter to sit through first.

Released under CC BY-SA 4.0 — share it, adapt it, teach from it.

# Contents

|                                                                                            |            |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------|
| <b>Preface</b>                                                                             | <b>iii</b> |
| <b>1 Greetings</b>                                                                         | <b>1</b>   |
| 1.1 নমস্কার ( <i>nômoshkar</i> ) — “hello” . . . . .                                       | 1          |
| 1.2 ধন্যবাদ ( <i>dhônyobād</i> ) — “thank you” . . . . .                                   | 2          |
| 1.3 হ্যাঁ / না ( <i>hyā / nā</i> ) — “yes” and “no” . . . . .                              | 2          |
| 1.4 আচ্ছা ( <i>āchchhā</i> ) — “okay / I see” . . . . .                                    | 3          |
| 1.5 আসি ( <i>āshi</i> ) — “I’ll be going” (goodbye) . . . . .                              | 3          |
| 1.6 Recap . . . . .                                                                        | 4          |
| <b>2 Introducing Yourself</b>                                                              | <b>5</b>   |
| 2.1 নাম ( <i>nām</i> ) — “name,” a word older than Europe . . . . .                        | 5          |
| 2.2 আমার ( <i>āmār</i> ) — “my” . . . . .                                                  | 6          |
| 2.3 আমার নাম... ( <i>āmār nām ...</i> ) — “my name is...,” with no “is” . . . . .          | 6          |
| 2.4 তুমি / আপনি ( <i>tumi / āpni</i> ) — “you,” three ways . . . . .                       | 6          |
| 2.5 কি ( <i>ki</i> ) — “what” . . . . .                                                    | 7          |
| 2.6 তোমার নাম কি? ( <i>tomār nām ki</i> ) — “what’s your name?” . . . . .                  | 7          |
| 2.7 আলাপ করে ভালো লাগলো ( <i>ālāp kore bhālo lāglo</i> ) — “pleased to meet you” . . . . . | 7          |
| 2.8 The whole exchange . . . . .                                                           | 7          |
| <b>3 How Are You?</b>                                                                      | <b>9</b>   |
| 3.1 কেমন ( <i>kēmon</i> ) — “how,” another of the k- questions . . . . .                   | 9          |
| 3.2 তুমি কেমন আছো? — “how are you?” . . . . .                                              | 9          |
| 3.3 আমি ( <i>āmi</i> ) — “I,” cousin of English <i>am</i> . . . . .                        | 10         |
| 3.4 ভালো ( <i>bhālo</i> ) — “well,” and how to answer . . . . .                            | 10         |
| 3.5 কোনো ব্যাপার না ( <i>kono bāpār nā</i> ) — “no matter” . . . . .                       | 10         |
| 3.6 The whole exchange . . . . .                                                           | 11         |

|                                                                           |           |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------|
| <b>4 Farewells</b>                                                        | <b>13</b> |
| 4.1 আবাব ( <i>ābār</i> ) — “again” . . . . .                              | 13        |
| 4.2 দেখা হবে ( <i>dækhā hōbe</i> ) — “(we) will meet” . . . . .           | 13        |
| 4.3 আবাব দেখা হবে — “we’ll meet again” . . . . .                          | 14        |
| 4.4 কাল দেখা হবে ( <i>kāl dækhā hōbe</i> ) — “see you tomorrow” . . . . . | 14        |
| 4.5 The farewells . . . . .                                               | 14        |
| <b>5 The First Verbs</b>                                                  | <b>15</b> |
| 5.1 বলা ( <i>bôlā</i> ) — “to speak,” your first full verb . . . . .      | 15        |
| 5.2 আমি বাংলা বলি — “I speak Bengali” . . . . .                           | 15        |
| 5.3 থাকা ( <i>thākā</i> ) — “to live, to stay” . . . . .                  | 16        |
| 5.4 কাজ করা ( <i>kāj kôrā</i> ) — “to work” . . . . .                     | 16        |
| 5.5 Sentences about yourself . . . . .                                    | 17        |
| <b>6 Numbers One to Five</b>                                              | <b>19</b> |
| 6.1 ek dui tin chār pāch . . . . .                                        | 19        |
| <b>7 The Core Verbs</b>                                                   | <b>21</b> |
| 7.1 hōwā . . . . .                                                        | 21        |
| 7.2 jāwā . . . . .                                                        | 22        |
| 7.3 āsā . . . . .                                                         | 24        |
| 7.4 khāwā . . . . .                                                       | 25        |
| 7.5 dækhā . . . . .                                                       | 27        |
| 7.6 jānā . . . . .                                                        | 28        |
| <b>The Bengali script (reference)</b>                                     | <b>31</b> |

## Chapter 1

# Greetings

The Bengali greetings — and, taught through them, how to read the Bengali script and the one sound-shift that turns every Sanskrit word into something recognisably *Bengali*. Each lesson introduces the letters its word needs. *Practice lessons: lessons/BN-C01-\*.md.*

### 1.1 নমস্কার (*nômoshkar*) — “hello”

#### The letters in this word

(If you already read Bengali, skim this.) Bengali runs **left to right** under a top line, and every consonant carries a built-in vowel — but in Bengali that vowel is **ô** (an open “o”), *not* “a.” ন *nô*, ম *mô*, ক *kô*, র *rô*. A **vowel sign** changes it (া *ā*); a *hasanta* under ঞ strips the vowel so it joins the next as a conjunct: ঞ + ক → ঞ্চ.

#### The word, taken apart — its roots and family

নমস্কার is the *same word* as the Sanskrit *namaskāra* you met in Hindi and Marathi (*namas* “a bow” + *kāra* “the making of”) — but listen to what Bengali does to it. The inherent “a” becomes **ô**, and *s* shifts to **sh**, so the written *namaskāra* is *spoken* **nômoshkar**. That one habit — *a*→*ô*, *s*→*sh* — is the fingerprint of Bengali, and once you hear it you can un-shift almost any word back to its Sanskrit cousin.

#### Why it’s said this way

*Nômoshkar*, palms together, is the everyday respectful greeting among Bengali Hindus and in formal speech generally — hello and, often,

goodbye. Bengali Muslims more often exchange *as-salāmu alaiikum* / *nāmāskār* by community; *nômoshkar* is the broad, secular-to-Hindu default. Bengali is the language of Tagore — the only tongue to have written the national anthem of *two* countries, India and Bangladesh.

## 1.2 ধন্যবাদ (*dhônyobād*) — “thank you”

### The letters in this word

New: ধ *dhô* (breathy *d*), ব *bô*, দ *dô*, and the conjunct ন্য (ন + য *y*). With the া sign, read ধন্যবাদ as *dhô · nyo · bā · d*.

### The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ধন্যবাদ is Sanskrit *dhanya* (“worthy”) + *vāda* (“a saying”) — the very “thank you” you learned in Hindi (*dhanyavād*), Marathi, and Punjabi. Two Bengali quirks show at once: the inherent *a*→*ô* again (*dhônyobād*), and **no separate “v”** — Bengali has only ব, so Sanskrit *vāda* is spoken *bād*. *V* becoming *b* is a Bengali signature (think of *Bishnu* for *Vishnu*).

## 1.3 হ্যাঁ / না (*hyā / nā*) — “yes” and “no”

### The letters in this word

New: হ *hô*, the *y-phola* াঁ that glides the sound, and the nasal mark *chandrabindu* ঁ (a moon-with-dot) that sends the vowel through the nose. না is simply ন + া *nā*.

### The word, taken apart — its roots and family

হ্যাঁ (*hyā*, “yes”) and না (*nā*, “no”). That “no” rides the ancient negative *na-* — the same Proto-Indo-European *\*ne* behind English **no**, **not**, **none**, Latin *nōn*, and Hindi *nahīn*. Bengali kept it at its shortest, bare *nā*: the family resemblance to English *no* is right on the surface.



## 1.4 আচ্ছা (āchchhā) — “okay / I see”

## The letters in this word

New: আ — the **independent** vowel ā, the shape a word uses when it *starts* with a vowel (a built-in vowel rides a consonant; a standalone one gets its own letter). Then the doubled ছ (চ *ch* + ছ *chh*). Read আচ্ছা as ā · chchhā.

## The word, taken apart — its roots and family

আচ্ছা (āchchhā) is the all-purpose “okay, alright, I see, go on” — a true workhorse of spoken Bengali, from Sanskrit *acchā* (“good, clear”). It is the little word that keeps a conversation moving; a Bengali speaker will pepper speech with āchchhā... āchchhā the way an English speaker says “right... right.”

## 1.5 আসি (āshi) — “I’ll be going” (goodbye)

## The letters in this word

New: স again — here truly “sh” — and the ি sign (*i*), which in Bengali is *written before* the consonant it follows but *read after* it. আসি = আ + সি, ā-shi.

## The word, taken apart — its roots and family

আসি (āshi) literally means “**I come**” — from the verb *āsā* (“to come,” Sanskrit root shared with Hindi *ānā*). Yet it is how Bengalis say *goodbye*. Never “I’m leaving” (unlucky, too final) but “I’ll come [again]” — আসি or the fuller *āschhi* (“I am coming”). It is the very same “promise of return” farewell you met in Tamil and Marathi: a whole culture’s optimism folded into one verb.

## Grammar Lens

Notice Bengali marks no gender on the verb — *āshi* is “I come” whether a man or a woman says it. That sets it apart from Marathi (*yeto* m./*yete* f.) and Hindi, and makes Bengali verbs, in this one respect, simpler than its neighbours’.

## 1.6 Recap

| Bengali    |                  | Meaning                     |
|------------|------------------|-----------------------------|
| নমস্কার    | <i>nômoshkar</i> | hello / goodbye             |
| ধন্যবাদ    | <i>dhônyobād</i> | thank you                   |
| হ্যাঁ / না | <i>hyā / nā</i>  | yes / no                    |
| আচ্ছা      | <i>āchchhā</i>   | okay / I see                |
| আসি        | <i>āshi</i>      | goodbye (“I’ll come again”) |

One habit unlocks this whole chapter: Bengali’s inherent vowel is **ô**, not “a,” and its *s* leans toward **sh** while its *v* collapses to **b**. Hear those shifts and the “foreign” *nômoshkar* and *dhônyobād* snap back into the Sanskrit *namaskāra* and *dhanyavāda* you already knew. Next chapter: introducing yourself — *āmār nām...* (“my name...”) — and Bengali’s *tumi* / *āpni* (familiar / respectful “you”).

## Chapter 2

# Introducing Yourself

Now a first real exchange — giving your name, asking for someone else’s, and saying you’re glad to meet them:

আমার নাম মিরাল (āmar nām Mira — “My name is Mira.”)  
তোমার নাম কি? (tomār nām kī — “What is your name?”)

Built the same way as the greetings — each piece taken apart, its letters and root, then assembled. *Practice lessons: lessons/BN-C02-\*.md.*

### 2.1 নাম (nām) — “name,” a word older than Europe

#### The letters in this word

ন (nô) + া (long ā, overriding the inherent ô) + ম (mô) → নাম (nām).

#### The word, taken apart — its roots and family

নাম (nām) ← Sanskrit *nāman*, from Proto-Indo-European *\*h<sub>3</sub>nómn*, — the *same* root as English **name**, Latin *nōmen* (English **noun**), and Greek *onoma*. Bengali *nām* and English *name* are cousins from before either language existed.

## 2.2 আমার (*āmār*) — “my”

### The word, taken apart — its roots and family

আমার (*āmār*, “my”) is the possessive of আমি (*āmi*, “I”), on the first-person stem *ām-* ← Sanskrit *asmad*. Buried in it is the same ancient **m-** of English **me**, **my**, **mine** and Latin *mē*.

### Grammar Lens

**No gender here.** *āmār* never changes for gender, where Hindi and Punjabi have *merā* (m.) / *merī* (f.). Bengali threw grammatical gender away entirely — one of its great simplifications, which you will meet again and again.

## 2.3 আমার নাম... (*āmār nām ...*) — “my name is...,” with no “is”

আমার (my) + নাম (name) + name = “my name ...” → “my name is...” *Āmār nām Arun*.

### Grammar Lens

**Bengali drops “is” in the present.** There is *no verb*: Bengali sets “my name” beside “Arun” and the “is” is understood. This is the **zero copula** — for present-tense equations (X is Y), Bengali needs no “to be” (like Tamil, and unlike Hindi’s *merā nām ...hai*). A verb returns only for a *state* or *place* (Chapter 3).

## 2.4 তুমি / আপনি (*tumi / āpni*) — “you,” three ways

### The word, taken apart — its roots and family

তুমি (*tumi*, familiar “you”) ← Sanskrit *tvam*, from PIE \*tū — the same root as English archaic **thou**, Latin *tū*. Bengali grades respect in **three**: তুই (*tui*, intimate), তুমি (*tumi*, familiar), আপনি (*āpni*, respectful) — like Hindi’s *tū/tum/āp*. For a first meeting, *āpni*.

## 2.5 কি (*ki*) — “what”

### The word, taken apart — its roots and family

কি (*ki*, “what”) ← the interrogative stem *ka-*, PIE *\*k<sup>w</sup>o-* — the root behind English **wh-** and Latin *qu-*. Bengali’s questions nearly all begin with *k-*: *ki* (what), *ke* (who), *kôbe* (when), *kôthāy* (where), *kēmon* (how).

## 2.6 তোমার নাম কি? (*tomār nām ki*) — “what’s your name?”

তোমার (*tomār*, “your,” from *tumi*) + নাম (name) + কি (what) = “**your name what?**” — still *no* “*is.*” The respectful “your” is আপনার (*āpnār*, from *āpnī*): *āpnār nām ki?* — the one for a stranger.

## 2.7 আলাপ করে ভালো লাগলো (*ālāp kore bhālo lāglo*) — “pleased to meet you”

### The word, taken apart — its roots and family

আলাপ করে ভালো লাগলো — “having made [your] acquaintance, it felt good.” The key word আলাপ (*ālāp*, “acquaintance, conversation”) is **Sanskrit** (*ālāpa*, *ā-* “toward” + *lap* “to speak”) — the same *ālāp* that names the slow, exploratory opening of a *rāga*, where a musician “converses” with the notes.

## 2.8 The whole exchange

| Bengali              | English              |
|----------------------|----------------------|
| আমার নাম মির।        | My name is Mira.     |
| আপনার নাম কি?        | What’s your name?    |
| আমার নাম অরুণ।       | My name is Arun.     |
| আলাপ করে ভালো লাগলো। | Pleased to meet you. |

Every atom traced: *nām* (Sanskrit *nāman*, English *name*), *āmār* (first-person *ām-*, no gender), *ki* (root *ka-*, English *what*), *ālāp* (Sanskrit “conversing”). Two Bengali habits already: the **zero copula** (no “is”), and

**no grammatical gender.** Next chapter: *tumi kēmon āchho?* (“how are you?”).

## Chapter 3

# How Are You?

After the name comes the exchange everyone actually has — and, for the first time, Bengali brings back a verb “to be”:

তুমি কেমন আছো? (*tumi kēmon āchho* — “How are you?”)  
আমি ভালো আছি, ধন্যবাদ। (*āmi bhālo āchhi, dhōnnobad* — “I’m well,  
thank you.”)

*Practice lessons: lessons/BN-C03-\*.md.*

### 3.1 কেমন (*kēmon*) — “how,” another of the k-questions

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

কেমন (*kēmon*, “how, of what kind”) is from the interrogative stem *ka-*, PIE \**k<sup>w</sup>o-* — the root behind English **wh-** and Latin *qu-*. Bengali’s questions nearly all begin with *k-*: *kī*, *ke*, *kôbe*, *kôthāy*, *kēmon*.

### 3.2 তুমি কেমন আছো? — “how are you?”

The new word is আছো (*āchho*, “are you”), from the verb আছা (*āchhā*, “to be, exist, have”) + the familiar-you ending. So তুমি কেমন আছো? is “you how are?”, the verb last. Respectful: আপনি কেমন আছেন? (*āpni kēmon āchhen?*).

### Grammar Lens

**Now the copula returns.** Chapter 2’s zero copula covers *equations* (*āmār nām Arun*). But “how are you?” asks about a *state* — how you *exist* — and for that Bengali uses a real verb, **আছি** (*āchhā*). No verb for “my name is Arun”; a real verb for “how are you.”

## 3.3 আমি (*āmi*) — “I,” cousin of English *am*

### The word, taken apart — its roots and family

আমি (*āmi*, “I”) descends from Sanskrit **अस्मि** (*asmi*, “I am”), from PIE *\*h<sub>1</sub>es-* — the “to be” root that gives English **am** and Latin *sum*. So Bengali’s word for “I” is, at the root, a form of “**am**”: “I” and “am” were once one word. Its possessive is *āmār* (“my”).

## 3.4 ভালো (*bhālo*) — “well,” and how to answer

### The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ভালো (*bhālo*, “good, well, fine”) is the everyday Bengali “good,” likely from Sanskrit **ভদ্র** (*bhadra*, “good, auspicious”). It fills the language: *bhālo lāge* (“[I] like it”), *bhālobāsā* (“love,” literally “good-dwelling”). The reply: আমি ভালো আছি (*āmi bhālo āchhi*), “I am well.”

## 3.5 কোনো ব্যাপার না (*kono bāpār nā*) — “no matter”

### The word, taken apart — its roots and family

কোনো ব্যাপার না literally “[it’s] **no matter**” — *kono* (“any”) + ব্যাপার (*bāpār*, “matter, affair”) + না (*nā*, “not”). It serves as “it’s nothing / you’re welcome.” *Bāpār* is **Sanskrit** (*vyāpāra*, “dealing”), and *nā* you met in Chapter 1 — the ancient negative, PIE *\*ne*, behind English **no**, **not**, **none**.



### 3.6 The whole exchange

| Bengali                | English                     |
|------------------------|-----------------------------|
| তুমি কেমন আছো?         | How are you?                |
| আমি ভালো আছি, ধন্যবাদ। | I'm well, thank you.        |
| কোনো ব্যাপার না।       | No matter / you're welcome. |

Every atom traced: *kēmon* (the *k*- questions), *āmi* (Sanskrit *asmi*, English *am*), *bhālo* (Sanskrit *bhadra*), *nā* (PIE \*ne, English *no*). Next chapter: the farewells.



## Chapter 4

# Farewells

Chapter 1 gave you the tender আসি (*āshi*, “I’ll come [again]”). Its fuller, everyday form:

আবার দেখা হবে! (*ābār dākhā hōbe* — “We’ll meet again!”)

*Practice lessons: lessons/BN-CO4-\*.md.*

### 4.1 আবার (*ābār*) — “again”

#### The word, taken apart — its roots and family

আবার (*ābār*, “again”) is a native Indo-Aryan adverb with no tidy English cognate, but a familiar job: it turns a parting into a promise. Add it to Chapter 1’s *āshi* and you can say “we’ll meet *again*.”

### 4.2 দেখা হবে (*dākhā hōbe*) — “(we) will meet”

#### The word, taken apart — its roots and family

দেখা হবে literally “[a] seeing will happen” — দেখা (*dākhā*, “seeing,” from *dākhā* “to see”) + হবে (*hōbe*, “will be/happen,” future of *hōwā* “to be/become”). Bengali says “a meeting will occur” rather than “we will meet” — an impersonal, gentle promise of reunion.

#### Grammar Lens

**The impersonal future.** Many “we’ll...” expressions use **noun + *hōbe*** (“...will happen”): *dākhā hōbe* (“a seeing will happen”), *kôthā hōbe* (“a

talk will happen”). The event itself is the subject — no “we.”

### 4.3 আবার দেখা হবে (*ābār dækhā hōbe*) — “we’ll meet again”

আবার (again) + দেখা হবে (a seeing will happen) = “we’ll meet again.” It is the warm, explicit form of Chapter 1’s *āshi* — the subcontinent’s “promise of return” (Hindi *phir milenge*, Tamil *pōy varugiṛēṇ*), never a blunt “goodbye.”

### 4.4 কাল দেখা হবে (*kāl dækhā hōbe*) — “see you tomorrow”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

কাল (*kāl*) means **both “tomorrow” and “yesterday”** — the day on either side of today — from Sanskrit *kāla* (“time”), the very root behind Hindi’s *kal* and Punjabi’s *akāl* (“timeless”). The verb’s tense tells which: *kāl dækhā hōbe* (future → “tomorrow”). So the phrase is “tomorrow, a seeing will happen.”

### 4.5 The farewells

| Bengali        | English                           |
|----------------|-----------------------------------|
| আসি।           | I’ll come [again]. (Ch.1 goodbye) |
| আবার দেখা হবে। | We’ll meet again.                 |
| কাল দেখা হবে।  | See you tomorrow.                 |

Roots banked: *dækhā hōbe* (the impersonal “a seeing will happen”), *kāl* (*kāla* “time,” cousin of Hindi *kal*, Punjabi *akāl*). Next chapter: the first real verbs — *āmi bānglā bôli* — and Bengali’s total lack of gender.

## Chapter 5

# The First Verbs

Until now, “to be.” Now verbs that *act* — and the gloriously simple way Bengali conjugates them:

আমি বাংলা বলি। (*āmi bānglā bôli* — “I speak Bengali.”)

*Practice lessons: lessons/BN-C05-\*.md.*

### 5.1 বলা (*bôlā*) — “to speak,” your first full verb

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

বলা (*bôlā*, “to speak, say”) is a native Indo-Aryan verb (the same *bol-* as Hindi *bolnā*, Punjabi *bolṇā*). The ending -আ (*-ā*) is the infinitive; add -ই (*-i*) to the stem for “I speak”: *bôl-* + *-i* → বলি (*bôli*).

#### Grammar Lens

The verb changes for person — but *never* for gender. *āmi bôli* (I say), *tumi bôlo* (you say), *se bôle* (he/she says). There is no “he-form” vs. “she-form”: *se bôle* is “he says” and “she says.” Where Hindi and Punjabi make even “I speak” agree with the speaker’s gender (*boltā/boltī*), Bengali dropped grammatical gender entirely — one less thing to track, forever.

### 5.2 আমি বাংলা বলি — “I speak Bengali”

আমি (I) + বাংলা (*bānglā*, the object) + বলি (speak) — “I Bengali speak,” verb last. The name বাংলা (*bānglā*) is the language’s own word for itself

(English “Bengali” comes from it), descending from বঙ্গ (*bôngo*), the ancient name of the region — so the language is named after its land, the great delta of the Ganges.

### Grammar Lens

Because Bengali verbs carry no gender, this sentence is the *same* whether a man or a woman says it — unlike Hindi. And since *-i* already means “I,” you could drop *āmi*: *bānglā bôli* is a complete “I speak Bengali.”

## 5.3 থাকা (*thākā*) — “to live, to stay”

### The word, taken apart — its roots and family

থাকা (*thākā*, “to live, stay, remain”) is from Sanskrit স্থা (*sthā*, “to stand, stay”), the PIE root *\*steh<sub>2</sub>-* that also gives English **stand**, **stay**, **state** and Latin *stāre*. “I live in Kolkata” is আমি কলকাতায় থাকি (*āmi Kolkātāy thāki*) — stem + the *-i* “I,” no gender.

### Grammar Lens

“**In**” comes after the noun. কলকাতায় (*Kolkātāy*) = *Kolkata* + *-y* (“in, at”), on the noun’s *end*. Bengali uses **postpositions** where English uses prepositions.

## 5.4 কাজ করা (*kāj kôrā*) — “to work”

### The word, taken apart — its roots and family

করা (*kôrā*, “to do, make”) is from Sanskrit *kr* (“to do”), PIE *\*k<sup>w</sup>er-* — the root of Chapter 1’s *nômoshkar* (*namas* + *kāra*, “the *making* of a bow”) and of *karma*. And কাজ (*kāj*, “work”) is itself from Sanskrit *kārya* (also from *kr*). Bengali builds compounds as **noun** + করা: কাজ করা (*kāj kôrā*, “work-do” = “to work”). So *āmi kāj kôri* = “I work.”

## 5.5 Sentences about yourself

| Bengali            | English            |
|--------------------|--------------------|
| আমি বাংলা বলি।     | I speak Bengali.   |
| আমি কলকাতায় থাকি। | I live in Kolkata. |
| আমি কাজ করি।       | I work.            |

Three verbs, one gender-free engine: the *-i* “I” ending, the verb always last, and **never** a change for gender. Roots banked: *bôlā* (native), *thākā* (*sthā* → English *stand/stay*), *kôṛā* (*kṛ* — root of *nômoshkar*; *kāj* “work” ← *kārya*), and *bānglā* (*bôngo*, the Ganges delta). From here, Bengali’s sentences only grow.





## Chapter 6

# Numbers One to Five

### 6.1 এক, দুই, তিন, চার, পাঁচ — one to five

Bengali writes in its own script, but the words underneath are the same family you'd hear in Delhi or Mumbai — with one number that preserves something both of them lost.

You'll want to know: the five

|   | Bengali | said        |
|---|---------|-------------|
| 1 | এক      | <i>ek</i>   |
| 2 | দুই     | <i>dui</i>  |
| 3 | তিন     | <i>tin</i>  |
| 4 | চার     | <i>chār</i> |
| 5 | পাঁচ    | <i>pāch</i> |

The ঁ on *pāch* is the **chandrabindu**, the same moon-dot Hindi uses, nasalising the vowel.

#### The word, taken apart — its roots and family

| language | 2                                                             |
|----------|---------------------------------------------------------------|
| Sanskrit | stem <i>dvá-</i> (masc. <i>dváu</i> , fem./neut. <i>dvé</i> ) |
| Prakrit  | <i>do</i> / <i>duve</i>                                       |
| Hindi    | <i>do</i>                                                     |
| Marathi  | <i>don</i>                                                    |
| Bengali  | <i>dui</i>                                                    |

Hindi and Marathi flattened the old form into a single *o*. Bengali kept a trace of the following **-i**, which is why it has two syllables where its neighbours have one.

The *dv*- cluster itself is gone from the **numeral** in all of them. (Not from the languages — *dv*- is alive in words borrowed straight back out of Sanskrit, like Bengali দ্বার *dvār* “door.” It’s the everyday inherited word that simplified.)

And Bengali isn’t unique in keeping that vowel: **Assamese, Odia and Nepali** have *dui* too. Among the four languages in this chapter it stands alone; across the eastern Indo-Aryan languages it has plenty of company.

### The letters in this word

Bengali’s inherent vowel leans toward **o**, not *a* — which is why the greeting from Chapter 1 is *nomoshkar* where Hindi says *namaskār*.

You won’t hear that in these five numbers, as it happens: এক opens with the independent vowel এ, and none of the others has a bare inherent-vowel syllable either. Mentioned so you don’t go looking for it here — but keep it in mind the moment a word does have one.

Don’t let a neighbouring language’s spelling tell you how Bengali sounds.

### Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ek, dui, tin, chār, pāch”
- the twos — “dvā- ... do ... don ... **dui**”
- the Ch. 1 echo — “**nomoshkar**, not **namaskār**”

### Before you move on

Count to five in Bengali. (*Ek, dui, tin, chār, pāch.*) What does দুই keep that Hindi and Marathi flattened away? (**The following -i**, which is why it has two syllables.) Is Bengali alone in that? (**No** — Assamese, Odia and Nepali have *dui* too; it’s alone only among the four here.) Did the *dv*- cluster survive anywhere in the everyday numeral? (**No** — though *dv*- is alive in words re-borrowed from Sanskrit, like *dvār* “door”.) What is the ঁ? (The **chandrabindu**, nasalising the vowel.) Next: six to ten.

## Chapter 7

# The Core Verbs

### 7.1 হওয়া (hōwā) — “to be,” and the be-verb it stands beside

Chapter 2 said “my name Arun” with no verb at all. Chapter 3 put one back for “how are you.” Both were right, and this verb is why.

You’ll want to know: হওয়া

হওয়া — *hōwā* — to be, to become

আমি হই (*āmi hōi*), “I am, I become.” সে হয় (*se hōy*), “he is.” Its future is already in your mouth: হবে (*hōbe*) is the “will happen” inside Chapter 4’s *dækhā hōbe*.

#### The word, taken apart — its roots and family

হওয়া is Sanskrit  $\sqrt{bhū}$  (*√bhū*, “to become”) with the *bh*- worn down to a plain *h*-. *bhavati* → Prakrit *hoi* → Bengali *hō*-. The root is PIE *\*b<sup>h</sup>uH-*, “to grow, to become,” and English owns two of its children outright — **be** and **been**. Latin built *fuī* (“I was”) and *futūrus* on it, which is English **future**; Greek built *phúsis*, “growth, nature,” which is **physics**.

#### The letters in this word

হ is a soft, breathed *h* carrying Bengali’s inherent vowel — *hō*, not *ha*. ওয়া (*-wā*) is the tail every dictionary-form verb wears; you will meet it again on খাওয়া and যাওয়া.

**Grammar Lens: two be-verbs, and one of them is unfinished****what you mean****what Bengali uses**

my name is Arun

no verb at all

I have a book; it is here

আছে (*āchhe*)

he will be a teacher

হবে (*hōbe*)

আছ-, the verb behind Chapter 3’s *kemon āchho*, means **being present**. But it is unfinished: it has a present and a past, and nothing else at all. Push it into the future and it stops dead — so Bengali picks up হ- (*hōbe*), or Chapter 5’s থাকা (*āmi thākbo*, “I’ll be there”). One job, two verbs, split down the middle.

**Your turn**

Say these aloud:

- “hōwā” — be, become — then “āmi hōi”
- the future you already knew — “hōbe ... dākhā hōbe”
- which verb for “I have a book,” and which for “he will be a teacher”

**Before you move on**

Which Sanskrit root is *hōwā*, and which two English words are its brothers? (*√bhū*, “to become” — **be** and **been**.) What can আছ- not do? (**Anything past a present and a past** — it has no future of its own.) So what does Bengali reach for instead? (হবে, or থাকা.) Next: one verb, three levels of respect.

**7.2 যাওয়া (*jāwā*) — “to go,” and the respect that rides on the ending**

Chapter 2 gave you three different words for “you.” It did not tell you the rest of the bill: each one bends the verb a different way too.

**You’ll want to know: যাওয়া**

যাওয়া — *jāwā* — to go

আমি যাই (*āmi jāi*), “I go.” Same *-i* “I” ending as Chapter 5’s *bôli*, on the same *-wā* dictionary form you met a moment ago.

#### The word, taken apart — its roots and family

যাওয়া is Sanskrit  $\sqrt{\text{या}}$  (*yā*, “to go, to travel”), and the whole northern family walks on it: Hindi *jānā*, Marathi *jāne*, Gujarati *javũ*, Punjabi *jāṇā*. Sanskrit’s *y*-hardened to a *j*-sound right across eastern Indo-Aryan, which is why Bengali still writes the *y*-letter য but says *j*. Deeper than Sanskrit it goes to PIE *\*yeh<sub>2</sub>-*, “to travel” — and here is an honest limit: English kept **no** everyday word from that root. The nearest living cousin is Lithuanian *jóti*, “to ride.” A fake English cousin here would be worse than none.

#### The letters in this word

য is the letter Sanskrit reads as *y*; Bengali reads it as *j*, like জ. So a written *yā*- is a spoken *jā*- — an un-shift worth keeping, since it disguises dozens of familiar Sanskrit words.

#### Grammar Lens: the respect is not in the pronoun, it is in the ending

| who you are speaking to          | “you go”            |
|----------------------------------|---------------------|
| তুই ( <i>tui</i> , intimate)     | যাস ( <i>jāsh</i> ) |
| তুমি ( <i>tumi</i> , familiar)   | যাও ( <i>jāo</i> )  |
| আপনি ( <i>āpni</i> , respectful) | যান ( <i>jān</i> )  |

Three endings, one verb. And the same grading runs on into the third person: সে যায় (*se jāy*) is “he goes,” তিনি যান (*tini jān*) is “he goes” said of someone you respect — the very ending আপনি takes. Chapter 5 showed that the ending already means “I,” so the pronoun can be dropped. The register cannot. Choose *jāsh* or *jān* and you have placed yourself socially, pronoun or no pronoun.

#### Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “jāwā” — go — then “āmi jāi”
- the ladder — “jāsh ... jāo ... jān”

- the two third persons — “se jāy ... tini jān”

#### Before you move on

Give the three “you go” forms and who each is for. (*Jāsh* intimate, *jāo* familiar, *jān* respectful.) If you drop the pronoun, is the respect dropped too? (**No** — it is in the ending, and cannot be dodged.) Does English have a living cousin of this root? (**No** — Lithuanian *jóti* is as close as it gets.) Next: the verb that asks nothing about who you are.

### 7.3 আসা (*āsā*) — “to come,” the verb that never asks who you are

Chapter 1’s goodbye, *āshi*, was one form of this verb. Here is the whole of it — and the one question it refuses to ask you.

You’ll want to know: আসা

আসা — *āsā* — to come

আমি আসি (*āmi āsi*), “I come” — the farewell you already own. সে আসে (*se āse*), “he comes.” আপনি আসেন (*āpni āsen*), with last lesson’s respectful ending.

#### The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The আ- in front is Sanskrit’s *ā-*, “hither, toward” — the very prefix that turns going into coming. Hindi’s *ānā* is that *ā-* welded onto *yā-*, the go-verb of the last lesson: “go, but this way.” Bengali shows the same prefix on a different stem, and the honest position on that stem is that its history is unsettled; this course will not invent one for it.

#### The letters in this word

স is written for *s* and spoken, in this word, as *sh* — Bengali’s standing *s* → *sh* tilt, the same one that makes *namaskāra* into *nômoshkar*. So আসি is *āshi*, not *āsi*, though the dictionary form is romanized *āsā*.

## Grammar Lens: no gender, not here, not anywhere

| language | “I come,” man / woman                  |
|----------|----------------------------------------|
| Hindi    | <i>maini ātā hūmī / maini ātī hūmī</i> |
| Marathi  | <i>mī yeto / mī yete</i>               |
| Bengali  | <i>āmi āsi</i> — one form              |

Its sisters make you declare your gender to say the plainest thing in the world. Bengali does not. And this is not a shortcut for beginners that the grammar takes back later: **Bengali has no grammatical gender at all.** Not on verbs, not on nouns, not on adjectives. The past behaves the same way — আমি এলাম (*āmi elām*), “I came,” is one form for everyone, where Gujarati, which hides gender in its present, brings it straight back in *humī āvyo / humī āvī*.

## Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “āsā” — come — then “āmi āshi”
- the neighbours splitting in two — “ātā ... ātī” and “yeto ... yete”
- Bengali not splitting — “āmi āsi” — and its past, “āmi elām”

## Before you move on

What does the আ- on this verb mean, and where else have you met it? (**Hither, toward** — it is the ā- inside Hindi’s *ānā*.) How many forms of “I come” does a Bengali speaker need? (**One** — *āmi āsi*, whoever is talking.) Is that true of the nouns too? (**Yes** — Bengali has no grammatical gender anywhere.) Next: a verb that swallows more than food.

## 7.4 খাওয়া (khāwā) — “to eat,” and the drinking it also does

Every verb so far has meant roughly what its English gloss means. This one is wider than its gloss, and the extra width is the lesson.

## You'll want to know: খাওয়া

খাওয়া — *khāwā* — to eat

আমি খাই (*āmi khāi*), “I eat.” আপনি খান (*āpni khān*), with the respectful ending from two lessons back.

## The word, taken apart — its roots and family

খাওয়া is Sanskrit √*khād* (‘to chew, to bite’), smoothed through Prakrit *khā-*. Every neighbour eats with it: Hindi *khānā*, Marathi *khāṇe*, Gujarati *khāvũ*, Punjabi *khāṇā*.

Past Sanskrit the trail goes cold. *Khād-* has no secure Indo-European pedigree outside Indo-Aryan, so there is no English cousin here — and one will not be manufactured. Some roots are simply local, and saying so is part of the method.

## The letters in this word

খ is *kh*: a *k* with a puff of breath behind it. Its plain partner ক (*k*) is the letter in Chapter 5’s *kāj*. The puff is not decoration — it is the whole difference between two words, and Bengali gives each its own letter.

## Grammar Lens: Bengali eats its drinks

| Bengali                             | what it means                |
|-------------------------------------|------------------------------|
| জল খাওয়া ( <i>jôl khāwā</i> )      | to drink water — “water-eat” |
| চা খাওয়া ( <i>chā khāwā</i> )      | to drink tea                 |
| ওষুধ খাওয়া ( <i>oshudh khāwā</i> ) | to take medicine             |

Hindi keeps a second verb, *pīnā*, for drinking. Bengali’s everyday speech does not bother: whatever goes in the mouth is *khāwā*. There **is** a drink-verb — পান করা (*pān kôrā*), noun-plus-*kôrā* in exactly Chapter 5’s *kāj kôrā* shape, built on Sanskrit √*pā* (‘to drink’), whose Latin cousin *pōtāre* gives English **potion** and **potable**. But it belongs to writing and ceremony. Ask for tea in a Kolkata kitchen and you eat it.

## Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “khāwā” — eat — then “āmi khāi”



- the drinking Bengali eats — “jôl khāwā ... chā khāwā”
- the formal drink-verb and its English cousins — “pān kôrā ... potion, potable”

#### Before you move on

How do you say “drink water” in everyday Bengali? (জল খাওয়া — literally “water-eat.”) Which Sanskrit root is *khāwā*, and does English share it? ( $\sqrt{khād}$ , “to chew” — and **no**, the root goes no further than Indo-Aryan.) Which verb would a formal text use for drinking, and what English words does its root reach? (পান করা, from  $\sqrt{pā}$  — English *potion*, *potable*.) Next: one spelling, two vowels.

## 7.5 দেখা (dākhā) — “to see,” and a vowel that moves under a fixed spelling

Chapter 4 buried this verb inside *dākhā hōbe*, “a seeing will happen.” Prised out on its own, it carries a sound rule that runs through every verb in this chapter.

### You’ll want to know: দেখা

দেখা — *dākhā* — to see, to look

আমি দেখি (*āmi dekhi*), “I see.” সে দেখে (*se dākhe*), “he sees.” Read those two romanizations again — they are not the same vowel.

#### The word, taken apart — its roots and family

দেখা is traced to Sanskrit  $\sqrt{dṛś}$  (*dṛś*, “to see”) through the Prakrit stem *dekkha*–; Hindi’s *dekhna* is the same word. Sanskrit built *darśana*, “a viewing,” on that root, and further back it is PIE *\*derk-*, “to see clearly.” Greek took it for *dérkomai*, “I look,” and for *drákōn*, the sharp-gazing serpent — which English borrowed as **dragon**. Bengali’s “see” and England’s dragons are one word, wearing very different clothes.

#### The letters in this word

দ is a soft dental *d*, tongue on the teeth. The vowel sign ঁ on it is written identically every time — but Bengali says it either as a close *e*

(as in English *bay*) or an open *æ* (as in English *bat*), and the page will never tell you which.

### Grammar Lens: the ending decides the vowel

#### Bengali

#### said

আমি দেখি

*dekhi* — close *e*

সে দেখে

*dækhe* — open *æ*

তুমি দেখো

*dækho* — open *æ*

The rule: when the ending carries the high vowel *-i*, the stem vowel closes to *e*. Any other ending leaves it open at *æ*. That is **vowel harmony**, and the verb of the first lesson does it too — আমি হই (*hôi*, closed) against সে হয় (*hôy*, open). It is a rule your ear must carry alone, because the spelling never budges.

### Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*dækhā*” — then the pair, “*dekhi* ... *dækhe*”
- the same shift on the be-verb — “*hôi* ... *hôy*”
- the root and its odd English relative — “*dṛś* ... dragon”

#### Before you move on

Which ending closes the stem vowel to *e*? (**The *-i* of “I”** — *dekhi*, against *dækhe* and *dækho*.) Does the spelling record that? (**No** — *ঐ* is written the same either way; only the ear knows.) Which English animal shares this verb’s root? (**The dragon** — Greek *drákōn*, from PIE *\*derk-*.) Next: the last verb, and the knowing English lost.

## 7.6 জানা (*jānā*) — “to know,” and the knowing English gave up

Six thousand years ago this verb and the English word you are reading it with were the same word. They still are. But Bengali kept a distinction English threw away.

You'll want to know: জানা

জানা — *jānā* — to know

আমি জানি (*āmi jāni*), “I know.” আপনি জানেন (*āpni jānen*), respectfully.

#### The word, taken apart — its roots and family

জানা is Sanskrit √ज्ञा (*√jñā*, “to know”), the root under *jñāna*, “knowledge.” Behind it stands PIE *\*ǵneh₃-*, and English is full of its children: **know** and **knowledge** by the direct Germanic road; **notice**, **recognize** and **cognition** through Latin *nōscere*; **gnosis** and **diagnosis** through Greek *gignōskein*. Bengali *jāni* and English *know* are one verb, separated only by time.

#### The letters in this word

Sanskrit writes the root with ज्ञ, a knot of *j* and *ñ*. Bengali does not say *jñ* at all — it says **gg**, so *jñāna* comes out *ggān*. The plain verb spares you the knot: জানা is simply জা + না, *jā-nā*.

#### Grammar Lens: two knowings, and English has one word for both

| Bengali               | what it knows                        |
|-----------------------|--------------------------------------|
| জানা ( <i>jānā</i> )  | a fact, or how to do something       |
| চেনা ( <i>chenā</i> ) | a person or a place, by acquaintance |

আমি জানি — “I know” (that it is so). আমি তাকে চিনি (*āmi tāke chini*) — “I know him,” meaning I am acquainted with him. Say *jāni* of a person and you have said you know facts about them, which is a colder thing. English once had this line and lost it; French still walks it as *savoir* against *connaître*, German as *wissen* against *kennen*, Spanish as *saber* against *conocer*. And listen to *chini* beside সে চেনে (*se chæne*): the same vowel harmony as the last lesson, on a brand-new verb.

#### Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*jānā*” — know — then “*āmi jāni*”

- the other knowing — “āmi tāke chini”
- the harmony again — “chini ... chæne”
- the six verbs of this chapter — “hōwā, jāwā, āsā, khāwā, dækhā, jānā”

#### Before you move on

Which verb knows a person, and which knows a fact? (ঢেনা for people, জানা for facts — the *connaître* / *savoir* line.) Name three English children of this root. (**Know, notice, diagnosis** — Germanic, Latin, Greek.) Why does *chini* close its vowel where *chæne* keeps it open? (**Vowel harmony** — the *-i* ending closes the stem vowel, as in *dekhi*.) That closes the chapter: six verbs, no gender on any of them, and the respect always sitting in the ending.

# The Bengali script — a reference

Not to be read before the lessons — they teach reading through real words. This page gathers the system.

## The three facts

1. **Consonants carry a built-in vowel — and it is ô, not “a.”** ক kô, ন nô, ম mô — written left to right under a connecting top line, like Devanagari but with rounder shapes. This single fact ( $a \rightarrow \hat{o}$ ) is why Sanskrit words sound “Bengali.”
2. **A vowel sign changes it.** কা kâ, কি ki, কী kī, কু ku, কে ke, কো ko. The *i*-signs ি/ী are written *before* the consonant but read *after* it. A *chandrabindu* ঁ nasalises the vowel.
3. **Standalone vowels have their own letters.** A vowel that *starts* a word is written in full: আ ā, অ ô, ই i, উ u, এ e, ও o.

## Worth flagging

- **$s \rightarrow$  “sh.”** The letter স (and শ, ষ) is usually pronounced “sh” — আসি is *āshi*, not *āsi*.
- **No separate *v* or *w*.** Bengali has only ব *b*, so Sanskrit *vāda*  $\rightarrow$  *bād*, *Vishnu*  $\rightarrow$  *Bishnu*.
- **Conjuncts.** A *hasanta* strips a consonant’s vowel so it fuses with the next: স্ + ক  $\rightarrow$  স্ক, চ + ছ  $\rightarrow$  চ্ছ. Many conjuncts have special shapes you learn as you meet them.

## Bengali in the family

Bengali (*Bānglā*) is **Indo-Aryan** — from Sanskrit, like Hindi, Marathi, and Punjabi — and its script descends, with Devanagari, from the old Brahmi writing of India, which is why they share the hanging top line. It is spoken across West Bengal (India) and Bangladesh, and carries an immense literary tradition — Tagore’s poetry, the anthems of two countries. The lessons trace its Sanskrit roots and, where they reach, the wider Indo-European family that also shaped English.